

KESRIDEVSINH JHALA, 42

Gujarat

From the erstwhile ruling family of Wankaner, Kesridev Sinh is a Rajya Sabha member. He is the son of Congress leader and former Union minister Digvijayasinh Jhala

DIYA KUMARI, 54

Rajasthan

From the erstwhile Jaipur ruling family, Diya Kumari is a deputy CM. Her father, the late Bhawani Singh, had contested the LS polls as a Congress candidate while her step-grandmother, late Gayatri Devi, had been an MP from the Swatantra Party



UDAYANRAJE BHOSALE, 59

Maharashtra

The Satara MP is considered the 13th holder of the Chhatrapati title, originally accorded to Shivaji

KANAK VARDHAN SINGH DEO, 69

Odisha

From the former ruling family of Patna, Balangir, he is a deputy CM. His wife, Sangeeta Singh Deo, is the BJP MP from Balangir



VASUNDHARA RAJE, 72

Rajasthan

The former CM and former Union minister was born in the Scindia family of Gwalior and married into the Dholpur royal family. She is the sister of Yashodhara and the aunt of Jyotiraditya

SANGEETA SINGH DEO, 63

Odisha

Wife of Kanak Vardhan Singh Deo, she is the MP from Balangir

YADUVEER KRISHNADATTA WADIYAR, 33

Karnataka

The Mysore MP is a scion of the Wadiyar dynasty



AMRITA ROY, 62

West Bengal

The 'Rajmata' of Krishnanagar contested the 2024 LS polls from Krishnanagar and lost

party expands its reach across geographies and communities, it has been seeking icons it can use to rally voters, building statues or monuments in their name. Royals fulfil that purpose equally. Witness the prime minister's recent invocation of the legacy of Rajaraja Chola and his son Rajendra Chola I during a trip to Tamil Nadu.

GAME OF THRONES

The BJP's strategy is evident in the apparent relaxation of norms around ticket distribution and its policy of denying tickets to the kin of elected representatives. For instance, Vishvaraj Singh, the titular maharaja of Mewar and the BJP MLA from Nathdwara, Rajasthan, was fielded in the December 2023 assembly election and, six months later, his wife Mahima Kumari, too, was nominated for the Lok Sabha. Both won their respective polls.

Similarly, in Madhya Pradesh, tribal leader and minister Kunwar Vijay Shah, who hails from the erstwhile estate of Makrai, was nominated from Harsud. His brother contested in neighbouring Timarni, though he lost to his nephew from the Congress.

In the east, the BJP appointed party veteran and former royal Kanak Vardan Singh Deo of Balangir as a deputy CM of Odisha in 2024, while his wife Sangeeta Singh Deo was re-elected to the Lok Sabha. In West Bengal—a state once home to India's longest-running communist government—it nominated Amrita Roy, the 'Rajmata' of Krishnanagar, for the Krishnanagar Lok Sabha seat, though she lost the election. Earlier, in 2023, the party had sent self-styled Koch royal Anant Maharaj, who claims to be king of the Rajbanshi community in North Bengal, to the Rajya Sabha. His election was widely seen as an attempt to consolidate the Rajbanshi vote in the politically volatile region around Cooch Behar and Alipurduar. Likewise, the party nominated Kesridevsinh Jhala of Wankaner in 2023 and Devendra Pratap Singh of the former princely state of Raigarh to the Upper House in 2024, from Gujarat and Chhattisgarh, respectively.

What does cultivating royalty get the BJP at a practical level? "In the initial years after Independence, many members of the erstwhile royal families moved to cities from their places of residence. But, with tourism picking up, properties being converted into hotels, and many of them joining politics, the connect with the local people continued. In many instances, this translated into electoral advantage, making political parties nominate members of royal families," explains Ranjitsinh. Their royal status gives them winnability, which is a key factor in ticket distribution for the BJP, as MP minister Kailash Vijayvargiya points out.

The BJP's royal turn is not without its biases, though, often shaped by religious and historical narrative. In